



The Atlas Mountains

A barrier between the Mediterranean and Sahara, stretching from Morocco to Tunisia

Extending for around 1,600 miles (2,500km), the Atlas Mountains consist of several distinct subranges, which are interspersed with plateaus and gorges. The subranges include the Anti-Atlas and High Atlas in Morocco and the Tell Atlas in Algeria.

Product of collision

The bulk of the Atlas Mountains were pushed up by a collision between the African and Eurasian plates, with the main uplift taking place 30–20 million years ago. However, certain parts were created during an earlier period of mountain building, from around 250 million years ago. Today, the appearance of the Atlas varies between forested slopes in the north and much more arid southerly subranges. The

region contains some of the world's largest and most diverse mineral resources.



◀ MINERAL WEALTH

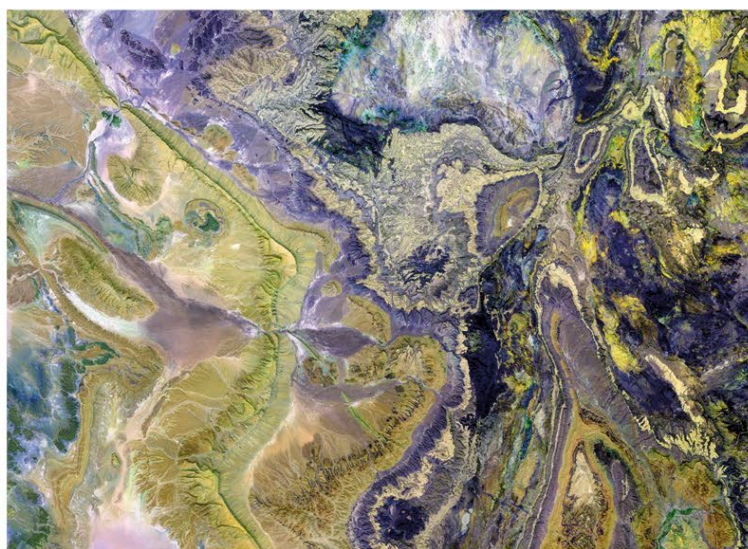
The Tell Atlas range of Algeria is mined in several locations for iron ore, as well as gold and phosphate. The chunk of iron ore shown here is of a type called hematite.

In **subtropical Africa**, the **tallest peaks** of the Atlas were **covered in glaciers** during the **last ice age**



△ MOUNT TOUKBAL

This small village, seen here in winter, is at the base of Mount Toukbal, the highest peak in the Atlas. Although there is snow on the peaks, the lower slopes are hot and arid.



◀ INTRICATE FOLDING

The Anti-Atlas is geologically complex. This satellite image, taken with an infrared camera sensitive to differences in surface composition, reveals intricate folding among the rock outcrops.